Barnstable County

Blizzard Hernando

After-Action Review

February 22 to 27, 2026 | Findings and the Path to Readiness

15 to 22 inches

75 mph gusts

153,000 outages

6 shelters

August 2026

The Incident

15-22"

heavy wet snow, 3-4 inches per hour at peak

75 mph

hurricane-force gusts, near-zero visibility

153,000

customers without power at peak

100%

of Outer Cape without power; telecom failures region-wide

Five days, start to finish

Sat 2/21

First regional call with about 200 participants; Blizzard Warning; State of Emergency

Sun 2/22

MACC activates 5:00 PM; Nauset and Barnstable Intermediate shelters open; snow begins

Mon 2/23

Storm peaks; Nauset heating fails and residents move to Dennis-Yarmouth; travel ban

Tue-Wed

Cape Tech opens; 17,000 meals under way; World Central Kitchen deploys; restoration ongoing

Thu-Fri

Command transitions after 96 hours; all shelters close Friday 1:00 PM; demobilization

The Response

What the county and its partners delivered

6

shelters: 4 regional plus Mashpee Wampanoag and Provincetown; 250+ residents at Dennis-Yarmouth at peak

14+

local warming centers and charging stations opened by towns

17,000

meals distributed by Family Table Collaborative with World Central Kitchen support

200

local, county, state, nonprofit, and utility partners on twice-daily regional calls

100s

of rides by Cape Cod RTA moving residents and pets to shelter, including a mid-storm evacuation

18

AmeriCorps Cape Cod members supporting shelters and the MACC around the clock

96 hrs

of continuous MACC command before a planned leadership transition

11+

regional coordination calls over five days through the BCREPC

How the Review Was Conducted

Consistent with FEMA's Continuous Improvement Technical Assistance Program and HSEEP

Who we heard from

20	county staff at the internal hotwash, by functional area
15	town health agents in a dedicated session
10	town emergency management directors
20	community partners: Red Cross, CCRTA, Family Table, Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe, ARES/RACES, Salvation Army
25	AmeriCorps members, alumni, and advisors
60+	survey responses across all instruments, plus document review

How findings are categorized

Critical — Significant operational effects that may lead to mission failure or harm. Requires immediate senior leadership attention.

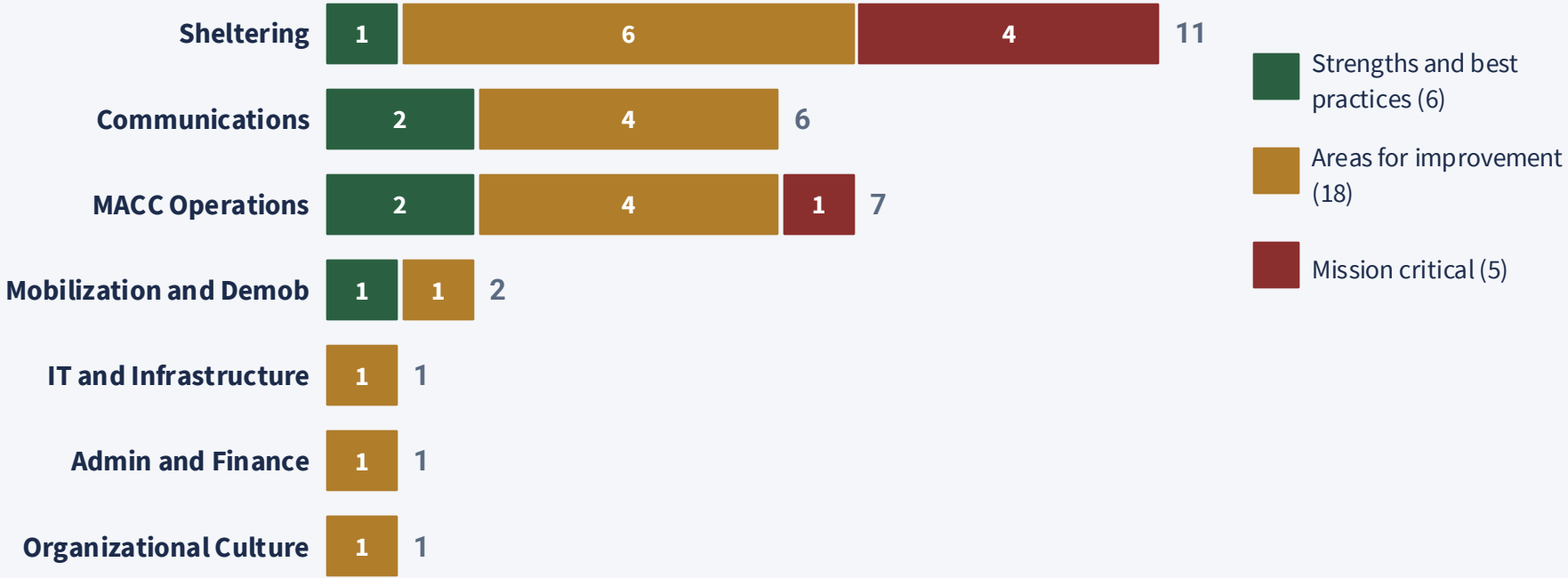
Improve — Activities that produced outcomes below expectations.

Strength — Activities within policy that yielded the desired result. Sustain and institutionalize.

Best Practice — Activities outside established policy that worked better than expected. Worth broader adoption.

Findings at a Glance

29 findings across 7 focus areas



The response succeeded because people compensated for structural gaps. Most findings describe problems that predated the storm.

Findings: Sheltering

11 findings, including 4 of the 5 mission critical items

Best Practice	**Local shelter models outperformed**	Document the Dennis-Yarmouth feeding and Provincetown locally controlled models in the revised plan.
Improve	**Facility readiness and use agreements not current**	Annual pre-storm inspections; updated facility agreements with a single point of authority.
Improve	**No standard credentialing or discharge planning**	Adopt a standard identification protocol; add discharge planning to shelter intake.
Improve	**Roles unclear; community capacity untapped**	Update Red Cross agreements; create AmeriCorps MOAs; build sub-regional staffing models and a surge capacity plan.
Critical	**County engaged without signed agreements**	Execute MOAs with towns and partners; build job action sheets for all shelter positions.
Critical	**2017 Regional Sheltering Plan outdated and unpracticed**	Revise as a framework that scales local capacity regionally, without relying on AmeriCorps.
Critical	**Medical and food staffing critically inadequate**	Set floors: one RN and one CNA per activation; one ServSafe-certified staff member per site.

Findings: Communications

6 findings

Strength	**The communications plan and Sitrep template held up**	Codify the Sitrep template and distribution protocol as a standard attachment; review the plan annually.
Improve	**The PIO function cannot sustain a multi-day activation**	Designate assistant PIO; establish a pre-event communications team activated at storm watch; build a misinformation response protocol.
Improve	**No degraded communications protocol exists**	Develop the protocol; pre-position satellite connectivity; integrate the AM radio station into the plan with defined activation triggers.
Improve	**Non-English-speaking residents lacked information access**	Develop templates in Portuguese, Spanish, and Arabic; procure a website translation widget; build relationships through community organizations.
Improve	**Health agents were not integrated into the response**	Formally incorporate health agent notification and coordination as a Health and Environment support role; develop job action sheets for health agents.

Findings: MACC Operations

7 findings, including 1 mission critical

Best Practice	**The BCREPC can anchor regional preparedness**	Develop an annual Integrated Preparedness Plan using the HSEEP framework; restructure storm calls around a community lifelines model.
Strength	**External partners performed reliably**	Review and develop MOAs with CCRTA and Family Table Collaborative to formalize their roles in future activations.
Improve	**WebEOC was not consistently used**	Establish a standard that all MACC activities are documented through WebEOC; train all relevant staff before next storm season.
Improve	**County services and statewide mutual aid underused**	Develop a protocol for activating the county helpline and resource referral; strengthen Mass 211 coordination; pursue Massachusetts VOAD membership.
Improve	**The equipment cache infrastructure needs modernization**	Pursue funding for a climate-controlled storage facility; transition from Conex box storage to a trailer-based deployment model.
Critical	**No formalized Incident Support Model exists**	Formalize the ISM; build an overnight and extended-activation staffing model; set protocols for elected official participation during activations.

Findings: Supporting Functions

IT and Infrastructure, Administration and Finance, Mobilization and Demobilization, Organizational Culture

Improve	**IT recovery work had no pathway into MACC awareness**	Formally assign IT a defined role within the MACC and EOC structure; integrate GIS and IT dashboarding into operational workflows.
Improve	**Finance was not embedded in the MACC from the outset**	Establish a standard that a dedicated finance function is embedded from activation start, protecting FEMA reimbursement documentation.
Strength	**The MACC leadership transition was handled cleanly**	Develop a documented staff rotation plan with defined trigger points; incorporate extended activations into the annual exercise cycle.
Improve	**No activation triggers or demobilization procedures existed**	Support a town-led regional shelter activation matrix with pre-set thresholds; develop a formal demobilization checklist.
Improve	**County staff lack ICS training and role clarity**	Require ICS 100, 200, 700, and 800 as baseline certifications; build a county-wide skills inventory; distribute job action sheets.

The Five Mission Critical Findings

Issues that could lead to mission failure or harm without senior leadership attention

Sheltering roles and agreements are not current	The county responded without signed agreements defining its role. Execute MOAs with towns and partners; build job action sheets for every shelter position.
The 2017 Regional Sheltering Plan is outdated	Never socialized, practiced, or updated. Comprehensively revise it as a framework that scales local capacity to a regional system.
Medical staffing at shelters was critically inadequate	No model existed for minimum medical staffing. Set a floor of one RN and one CNA per activation and write it into plans and MOUs.
Shelter food service lacked certified staff	Require at least one ServSafe-certified staff member per site; engage health agents for food safety oversight.
No formalized Incident Support Model	Command arrangements were improvised. Formalize the ISM, build an overnight and extended-activation staffing model, and set protocols for elected official participation.

What Went Well and the Path Forward

Worth keeping and formalizing

- Communications plan and Sitrep template held up through the full activation
- MACC leadership transition at 96 hours was handled cleanly
- Family Table Collaborative and Cape Cod RTA performed reliably
- Dennis-Yarmouth feeding model and Provincetown locally controlled shelter model are replicable
- Volunteers, AmeriCorps, and municipal staff showed extraordinary commitment

Before next storm season

- Revise the Regional Sheltering Plan and execute MOAs with towns and partners
- Formalize the Incident Support Model and EOC concept of operations
- Set minimum shelter staffing standards for medical and food service
- Require ICS baseline training for county staff and build job action sheets
- Exercise the revised plans in the fall regional shelter exercise

The measure of this review is not the quality of the document. It is the state of the county's emergency management system when the next event tests it.